

Pain Relievers

also known as painkillers or analgesics

Different types of pain relieving medicines are available for treating different types of pain. Pharmacists and doctors can advise you on the best pain relievers for your pain.

When an area of the body is damaged or stressed, nerves from the affected area carry a message to the brain, which we call pain. Pain is an unpleasant sensation or feeling that may be mild or severe, sharp or dull and acute or chronic.

Acute pain

Acute pain is pain that comes on suddenly and lasts for a limited time. It may be mild or severe and may last a few minutes, hours, days or weeks. Examples of acute pain include insect bites, headaches, burns and broken bones.

Chronic pain

When pain lasts for longer than three months, it is called chronic pain.

Chronic pain may be due to a chronic medical condition (e.g. arthritis), but

sometimes the cause isn't known. Sometimes chronic pain is due to a problem with nerve function. A nerve sends pain messages to the brain even though there may not be any tissue damage. This type of nerve pain is called neuropathic pain.

Using pain relievers

Pain relieving medicines don't always stop all pain, but can reduce pain to a level that does not affect daily life. There are a number of different types of pain relievers that work in different ways and suit different types of pain. The choice of a pain reliever and how well it relieves the pain depend on a number of things including:

- The type of pain, where it is occurring and how strong it is

- The form of pain reliever. Pain relievers are available in a variety of different forms including soluble tablets, immediate-release tablets, slow-release tablets, mixtures, injections, creams, gels and patches
- How often the pain reliever is used. Sometimes it is better to use pain relievers at regular intervals 'by the clock', rather than 'as needed'
- A person's age, medical condition(s) and other medicines.

Non-prescription pain relievers

Non-prescription pain relievers can be purchased from a pharmacy without a prescription.

Paracetamol

- Relieves mild to moderate pain (e.g. headache, muscle and joint pain, sciatica).
- Reduces fever.
- Is suitable for all ages.
- Is suitable for people who are sensitive to aspirin or other NSAIDs (e.g. children, people with gastro-intestinal (gut) or kidney problems, some people with asthma).
- If used correctly, has a low risk of side effects and interactions with other medicines compared to other pain relievers.

Paracetamol is available as tablets, capsules, mixtures and suppositories.

Non-Steroidal Anti-Inflammatory Drugs (NSAIDs)

NSAIDs include aspirin, ibuprofen, naproxen and diclofenac. They:

- Relieve mild to moderate pain
- Reduce inflammation (e.g. gout, arthritis)
- Reduce fever.

NSAIDs are available as tablets, capsules, mixtures, creams and gels.

All NSAIDs may cause serious side effects. Check with a pharmacist or doctor before using NSAIDs, especially if you:

- Are sensitive to aspirin
- Are pregnant or trying to become pregnant
- Have asthma, high blood pressure, heart failure, kidney problems or gastro-intestinal problems
- Take a medicine or have a medical condition that reduces blood clotting
- Take any other medicines
- Have recently had or will be having surgery or dental work.
- Have a muscle or joint injury

Stop taking NSAIDs and seek medical advice if you have swollen ankles, breathing problems, unexplained bruising, heartburn, black faeces or coffee-coloured vomit.

Codeine

Non-prescription pain relievers containing codeine can only be obtained from a pharmacist, who must approve and advise on their use. Codeine is available in combination with aspirin, ibuprofen or paracetamol. These codeine containing products:

- May give stronger pain relief than paracetamol, aspirin or ibuprofen alone. However, codeine is not suitable for everyone
- Are not recommended for relief of migraine
- May cause nausea, drowsiness, dizziness, constipation, breathing problems and other side effects
- Can cause dependence and withdrawal symptoms if not used correctly.

Combination products

- Some products contain paracetamol or an NSAID combined with codeine and/or other medicines (e.g. cold and flu products, some migraine products). Always check the ingredients of combination products, in order to avoid taking an overdose of pain relievers.

Important

Always ask a pharmacist or doctor for advice about the best pain reliever for your pain, and about the best way to use it. Using pain relievers the wrong way can be harmful.

- High doses or constant use of certain pain relievers can lead to serious kidney, liver or gastro-intestinal damage.
- Regular use of certain pain relievers (e.g. codeine) can cause physical and psychological dependence (addiction).
- Some pain relievers interact with other medicines.
- Repeated use of pain relievers for headaches may cause medication overuse headache.
- Aspirin may cause a serious adverse reaction in children. It should not be used by children under 16 years unless advised by a doctor.

- Some pain relieving products contain caffeine, which may increase the pain relieving effect of paracetamol. If you want to use these products, ask a pharmacist for advice before using other products containing caffeine (e.g. tea, coffee, cola, energy drinks, chocolate).

Prescription pain relievers

Higher doses and stronger pain relievers can be prescribed by a doctor for more severe pain or neuropathic pain.

Self care

- Check with a pharmacist or doctor if you need to use a pain reliever for more than three days in a row.
- Read all medicine labels and follow the directions.
- Do not take more than the recommended dose of a pain reliever. Give children the correct dose for their age and weight, according to the instructions on the label.
- Do not take pain relievers to continue working or playing sport when injured.
- Remember that pain can also be reduced by non-medicine means, (e.g. hot/cold packs, physiotherapy, TENS, relaxation, massage, exercise). Ask a doctor, pharmacist or physiotherapist for advice.
- Learn and use relaxation techniques to manage stress – especially if stress brings on pain such as headache.
- Alert your doctor, dentist and pharmacist if you are taking pain relievers regularly.

For more information

Healthdirect Australia

Phone: 1800 022 222

Website: www.healthinsite.gov.au

Consumer Medicine Information (CMI)

Your pharmacist can advise on CMI leaflets.

National Prescribing Service (NPS) Medicines Information

Phone: 1300 MEDICINE (1300 633 424)

Website: www.nps.org.au

The Poisons Information Centre

In case of poisoning phone 13 11 26 from anywhere in Australia.

*Pharmacists are medicines experts.
Ask a pharmacist for advice when
choosing a medicine.*

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ALWAYS READ THE LABEL. For temporary relief of pain and fever. Use only as directed. Incorrect use could be harmful. Consult your healthcare professional if symptoms persist.

Your Self Care Pharmacy: